I would sever links with the civil service, which nurtured and defined me all through my adult life, so nonchalantly.

On 5 September 2008, I took an early-morning Air India flight from Delhi to Mumbai, a two-hour journey that would mark by far the most significant transition of my career. Even as I was drained—physically, mentally and emotionally—I couldn’t keep my mind away from the potential challenges and concerns about how I might perform as the governor of the Reserve Bank of India.